

Valence Asymmetries Workshop
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A grammaticalization path of *puta*: semantic bleaching of a derogatory term in talk-in-interaction

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Grammaticalization: a dyachronic process



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- “Grammaticalisation consists in the increase of the range of a morpheme advancing from a lexical to a grammatical or from a less grammatical to a more grammatical status, e.g. from a derivative formant to an inflectional one.” (Kurylowicz 1975[1965]: 52)



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- **Process of change correlates with more frequent uses:** weakening of semantic force by habituation; phonological reduction and fusion; greater autonomy; new pragmatic associations; new felicitous contexts of use. (Bybee 2017: 604).



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- **Process of change correlates with more frequent uses:** weakening of semantic force by habituation; phonological reduction and fusion; greater autonomy; new pragmatic associations; new felicitous contexts of use. (Bybee 2017: 604).
- This process can be studied synchronically through comparative studies (see Langacker 2011; Cavirani et al 2024; Sansò 2022; Posio & Rosemeyer 2025)



Roadmap

1. **Puzzle:** *puta*, a derogatory term and a discourse particle
2. **Data:** talk-in-interaction corpora of Spanish varieties
3. **Manual annotation** of *puta* based on syntagmatic relations
4. **Analysis** of *puta* as a discourse particle from a CA perspective
5. **Proposal:** two parallel grammaticalization paths of *puta*
6. **Conclusions** and future work



puta as a derogatory term

In Spanish, *puta* (‘whore’) can occupy several parts-of-speech to encode various types of meanings.

As a derogatory term, the speaker expresses a strong negative evaluation towards a subject (McCready 2010; Gutzmann 2011; Saab 2020) with a gender-biased interpretation.

- (1) a. Es-**a** *puta***a** no sabe lo que hace
 That-F *whore* NEG knows ACC.3SG that do.PRS.3SG
- b. Ella es un-**a** *puta***a**
 She is one-F whore
- c. Puta! Ven aquí
 VOC come.IMP.2sg here



puta as an expressive

In some varieties of Spanish (e.g., Rioplatense and Peninsular Spanish), *puta* also acts as a pure expressive as it modifies items by only expressing the speaker's attitude (Potts 2007; Gutzmann 2019).

- (2) a. No tengo un ***put-o*** ***duro***
NEG have.PRS.1SG one *fucking-M* hard ($\cong$ euro)
- b. Volvió a ganar. ¡Qué ***put-a*** ***suerte*** tiene!
return.PST.3SG to win.INF what *fucking-F* luck have.PRS.3SG
- c. Esa bicicleta ***funciona*** ***de puta*** ***madre***
That-F bicycle work.PRS.3SG of whore mother

Puta is interpreted as conveying negative or positive affective evaluations towards a discourse referent. As it still exhibits GEN/NUM agreement, the form behaves as a semi-lexical item (Cavirani-Pots 2020; Cavirani et al. 2024).



puta as a discourse particle

Puta also works as an action boundary in between utterances for evaluating contextually salient propositions (Schiffrin 1987; Maschler & Schiffrin 2015):

- (3) a. Utterance without propositional material (SCL_004_03_18)

pu(h)ta(h) Marle(h)
PRT, Marle

- b. Turn-initial position (IQQ_007_11_12)

puta de diez mil (.) ¿tú no tení m'hija? (.) ¿dos de cinco?
PRT, [a bill] of ten thousands. Don't you have, dear, two fives?

- c. Turn-medial position (TCO_008_03_20)

eh sabes que, puta si quieren tirar van a tirar
You know what, PRT, if you guys want to hook up, you'll hook up

- How can the different uses of *puta* be explained within a grammaticalization account?
- How can this account explain the varietal differences and similarities in the use of *puta*?

PROPOSAL

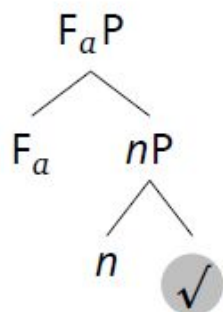
Two grammaticalization paths, operating in parallel and at different stages in each variety:

- **Root-based, bottom-up path**, at a propositional level
- **A monologization path**, at an interactional level

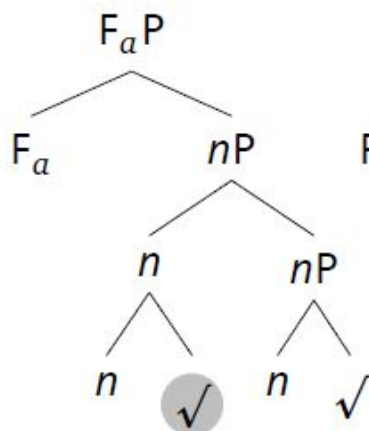
Root-based, bottom-up path

Four stages of grammaticalization (Cavirani-Pots 2020)

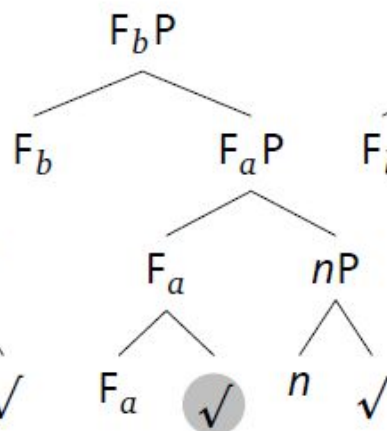
Stage 0



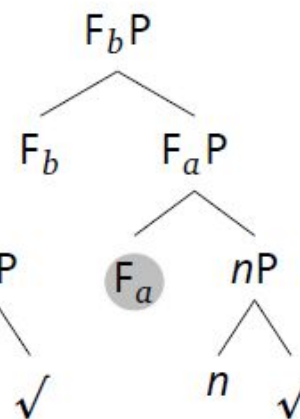
Stage I



Stage II



Stage III



(in Cavirani et al. 2024: 18)



Proposal

Root-based, bottom-up path

A monologization path: “progressive emancipation of a given element from a dialogic structure to become an autonomous, monological marker/construction, which no longer requires the original dialogic structure in which it was embedded in order to be felicitously uttered.” (Sansò 2022: 202).

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Stage I	Stage II	Stage III
<i>Bueno</i> mitigates a dispreferred response in dialogical contexts	<i>Bueno</i> is used in monological contexts and can be described as a dispreferred response to a fictive first pair part Topic management functions	<i>Bueno</i> is used in monological contexts, but can no longer be described as a dispreferred response to a fictive first pair part Perspective management functions

(Posio & Rosemeyer 2025: 17)



Data: audio recorded interactions



Dyadic structured
interviews



Multi-party,
naturally-occurred
conversations

“While Spanish dialects [and varieties] are generally considered mutually intelligible (Merino/Grijelmo 2019), certain lexical items can nonetheless be treated as problematic for mutual understanding.” (Satti, to appear)

***puta* in colloquial conversations (AMERESCO)**



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Country	Size of Corpus	Number of cases	Frequency (per 100k tokens)
México	362.026	38	10,49
Chile	147.759	53	35,86
Cuba	102.890	3	2,91
Argentina	92.747	16	17,25
Colombia	41.825	9	21,51
Honduras	36.722	16	43,57
España	12.528	5	39,91
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TOTAL	800.084	141	17,62

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Venezuela	430.055	2	0,47
Perú	149.747	13	8,68
Chile	162.720	70	43,02
Argentina	140.659	3	2,13
Bolivia	127.501	11	8,63
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Higher frequency of use of the form in one variety respect to the rest is evidence of a functionalization process (Bybee 2017)



Methodology

- Instances of use of *puta* were manually annotated based on its syntagmatic relations and prosodic integration within a sentence.
- Cases with no clear integration nor sentential function were categorized as PARTICLES.
- These cases were further analysed following Conversation Analytical notions.



Methodology: manual part-of-speech annotation

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ADJ	Spain	vamos catorce tíos a la puta calle así de claro
ADV	Spain	me abraza y me dice “tío / cantas de puta madre no sé qué tal ”
EXPLT/ MDFR	Honduras	¡ah! pero me piden aquí otra onda que es una<alargamiento/> no me acuerdo qué putas era
PRT	CHILE	B: ohh / yo puta en mi trabajo / puta / me han pasado hartos sustos /



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	NOUN/ VOC/ EPITHET	ADJ	ADV	EXPLETIVE/ MODIFIER	DISCOURSE PARTICLE
España	✓	✓	de puta madre	[puta mierda ostia puta]	–
México	✓	✓	–	–	puta (madre)
Colombia	✓	[✓]	–	[QU- + putas]	(joe)puta
Venezuela	✓	–	–	–	(a la) puta
Perú	✓	–	–	–	puta (madre)
Chile	✓	[#]	–	–	✓
Argentina	✓	✓	–	–	puta (madre)
Bolivia	✓	–	–	–	✓
Guatemala	✓	–	–	–	✓
Ecuador	✓	–	–	–	✓
Cuba	✓	✓	–	–	puta de tu madre
Honduras	✓	✓	–	QU- + putas	(jue)puta

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España	✓			ta mierda a puta]	–
México	✓			–	puta (madre)
Colombia	✓			J- + putas]	(joe)puta
Venezuela	✓			–	(a la) puta
Perú	✓			–	puta (madre)
Chile	✓			-	✓
Argentina	✓			–	puta (madre)
Bolivia	✓			–	✓
Guatemala	✓			–	✓
Ecuador	✓			–	✓
Cuba	✓			–	puta de tu madre
Honduras	✓	✓	–	QU- + putas	(jue)puta



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Argentina	✓			–	puta (madre)
Bolivia	✓			–	✓
Guatemala	✓			–	✓
Ecuador	✓			–	✓
Cuba	✓			–	puta de tu madre
Honduras	✓	✓	–	QU- + putas	(jue)puta





A Conversation Analytical approach

“(...) particles are used as resources for forming and managing social action, and, consequently, (...) they are deployed to achieve a variety of interactional activities, including:

- organizing courses of action;
- repairing problems of speaking and understanding;
- coordinating turn-taking;
- conveying epistemic, affective, relational, and other stances.”

(Bolden 2024: 613)



A Conversation Analytical approach

Questions to guide the analysis:

- How does the particle **contribute to the unfolding action**?
- What is the **particle's position** by reference to various conversational organizations and how does that position contribute to the in-progress action?
- How is the analysis grounded in **participants' orientations**?

(Bolden 2024: 616)



Positions of *puta* in AMERESCO

	PARTICLE	EXPLETIVE	ADJ	Total
<i>puta</i>	48 (90,56%)	2 (3,77%)	3 (5,66%)	53 (100%)

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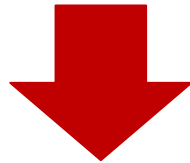
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	without p-material	Turn initial	Turn medial	Fictive quotation	Turn final	Total
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1. *puta* within an utterance without p-material

- (4) [Marle, Anto and Coni are three classmates discussing the upcoming start of the term. Marle remembers that she was sick around that date.]

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01 Ma: y el año pasado yo partí el año refriá (...)
 and last year too I started the year with a cold (...)

02 y en primero también
 and first [year of college] too

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04 Con: en el verano po
 during summer

05 Ma: sí↑ po: fue en pleno verano:: (.) [si fue cuando::]
 yeah it was in mid summer (.) it was when

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SCL 004 03 18

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SCL_004_03_18

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**RESPONSIVENESS;
INDEXICALITY**

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OPEN CLASS!

06 Con:

[igual estábamos trabajando
 we were also working

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SCL_004_03_18

2. *puta* in turn-initial position

- (5) [Inside a taxi, the driver is with two passengers. One of them is paying for the ride with a bill that is too big.]

— — —

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01 Cl: °tome caballero°
here you go, sir

02 Driv: ¡ahh! ¿no tiene sencillo?
Ah! you don't have change?

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(5) [Inside a taxi, the driver is with two passengers. One of them is paying for the ride with a bill that is too big.]

- 01 Cl: °tome caballero°
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No, nothing

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PTR, [a bill] of ten thousands. Don't you have, dear, two fives?

05 Cl2: nada (.) vamos a ver pue'

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PTR, [a bill] of ten thousands. Don't you have, dear, two fives?

05 Cl2: nada (.) vamos a ver pue'
Nothing. Let's see.

06 Driv: por favo:r es que yo no te:ngo
Please, because I don't have [change].

IQQ_007_11_12

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No, nothing

 **OPTIONALLY MARKED PROSODY**

04 Driv:-> puta de diez mil (.) ¿tú no tení m'hija? (.) ¿dos de cinco?
PTR, [a bill] of ten thousands. Don't you have, dear, two fives?

05 Cl2: nada (.) vamos a ver pue'
Nothing. Let's see.

06 Driv: por favo:r es que yo no te:ngo
Please, because I don't have [change].

IQQ_007_11_12

(5) [Inside a taxi, the driver is with two passengers. One of them is paying for the ride with a bill that is too big.]

01 Cl: °tome caballero°
here you go, sir

02 Driv: ¡ahh! ¿no tiene sencillo?
Ah! you don't have change?

**RESPONSIVENESS;
PARTIAL RECOVERY IN
TURN**

03 Cl: °no nada°
No, nothing

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**BEGINNING
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IQQ_007_11_12

3. *puta* inside fictive quotation

- (6) [BAL's cat is sick. She wants to take her to a new veterinarian for having a second opinion. The problem is that if she does that, she will lose the cat's medical history.]

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And can't you ask for your medical history?

02 Bal: eh no (1.5) es que lo escriben como en su computador
eh no (1.5) it's just that they type it on their computer

SCL_004_03_18

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like PRT I'm gonna go to another doctor (.)

05 >o no sé (.) me cambio de casa<
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FICTIVE BUBBLE

SCL_004_03_18

4. *puta* in turn-medial position

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05 Ana:-> eh sabes que, puta si quieren tirar van a tirar porque hueón
You know what, PTR, if you guys want to hook up, you'll hook up because, man,

06 están pololeando y la huevada. (.) y ya no tienes que como que
you're dating and all that. And you don't have to, like,

07 estar conociendo gente, (.) y invitarlos a comer ¿cachái? a salir
meet new people, and invite them to eat, you know? Or go out.

TCO_008_03_20

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TCO_008_03_20

TOPIC MANAGEMENT; NO DEIXIS



Summary



Summary

Self-contained

Turn-initial

Fictivity

Turn-medial



Summary

Self-contained

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Turn-medial

**Target of
evaluation**

Prior turn

Prior turn

Turn inside turn

Host utterance



Summary

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**Trigger
source**

Addressee

Addressee

Speaker

Speaker



Summary

Self-contained

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Turn inside turn

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Trigger source

Addressee

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Speaker

Speaker

Epistemic evaluation

speaker-oriented:
unexpected,
newsworthy

speaker-oriented:
unexpected,
newsworthy

addressee-oriented:
dispreferred,
noteworthy

addressee-oriented:
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Summary

Self-contained

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**Target of
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**Affective
evaluation**

More affective;
deictic



Less affective;
discursive

Self-contained

Turn-initial

Fictivity

Turn-medial

Target of evaluation

Prior

Host utterance

Trigger source

Addressee

Speaker

Epistemic evaluation

speaker-oriented

addressee-oriented:

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noteworthy

Affective evaluation

More affective;
deictic



Less affective;
discursive

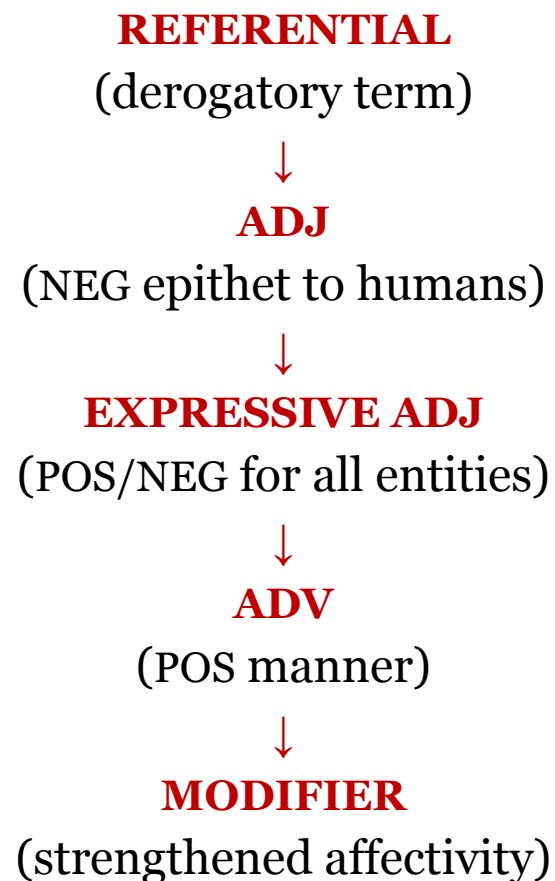
- How does this fit into a grammaticalization process?
- How does this relate to the other uses of *puta*?



Proposal

puta exhibits parallel paths of grammaticalization:

Root-based, bottom-up path (based on Cavirani-Pots 2020)

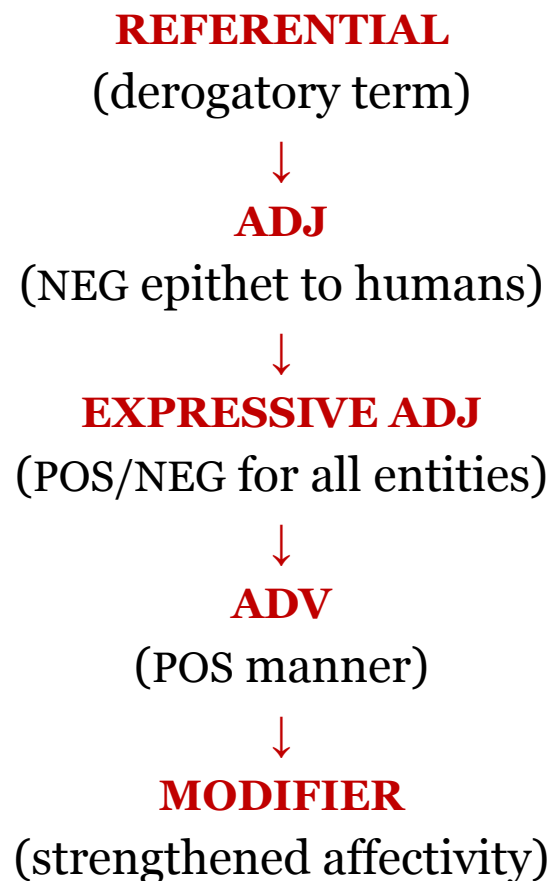




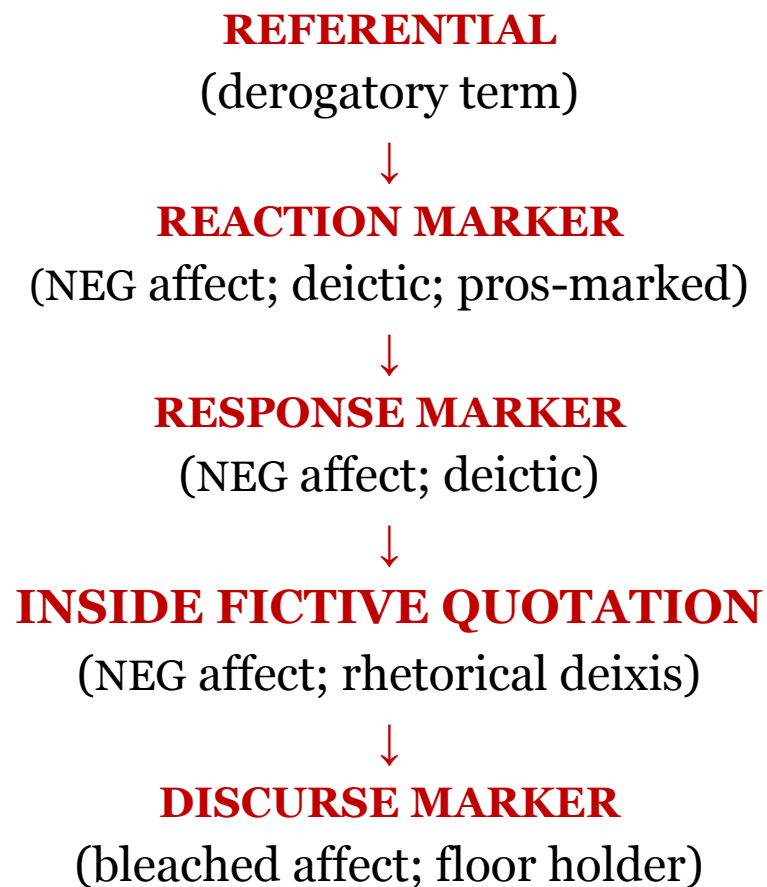
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Monologization path (based on Sansò 2022; Posio & Rosemeyer 2025)



puta exhibits parallel paths of grammaticalization:

Root-based, bottom-up path (based on Cavirani-Pots 2020)

REFERENTIAL
(derogatory term)



ADJ
(NEG epithet to humans)



EXPRESSIVE ADJ
(POS/NEG for all entities)



ADV
(POS manner)



MODIFIER
(strengthened affectivity)

Monologization path (based on Sansò 2022; Sansò & Rosemeyer 2025)

REFERENTIAL
(derogatory term)



REACTION MARKER
(NEG affect; deictic; pros-marked)



RESPONSE MARKER
(NEG affect; deictic)



INSIDE FICTIVE QUOTATION
(NEG affect; rhetorical deixis)



DISCURSE MARKER
(bleached affect; floor holder)

(+)

A
F
F
E
C
T

(-)

- Grammaticalization occurred as a parallel process and in various stages across varieties of a same language.
- Some varieties only exhibit a root-based grammaticalization path (European Spanish), other only a monologic path (Chilean Spanish), and others both (Colombian and Mexican Spanish).
- Interaction showed a structured organization that enabled (and was enabled by) the systematic use of such particles.
- CA perspective opened a window into the complex uses of discourse particles: turn-taking and epistemic/affective management.



Future work

- To verify the uses described on the table. Corpus most probably is not showing all uses.
- To analyse other items of the language to characterize their ecology and paradigmatic relations.
- To explain why expressivity triggers such a grammatical change.
- To analyse similar particles in other languages with different grammatical systems.
- **To find a grammatical theory capable of explaining both processes as part of the same system.**



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